

AWAITING THEIR TURN
People queue up at the state-run SSKM Hospital in Kolkata; (inset) a patient shows his Swasthya Sathi card

ON THE DRIP

*Of the **Rs 6,882 crore** spent on Swasthya Sathi*, the CAG cited lapses of Rs 117.6 cr. The main slip-ups:*

₹47 cr.
Excess spend on enrolment, smart cards (since Apr. '19)

₹31.3 cr.
Penalties not recovered from insurance cos (Jan. '20 to Jul. '22)

₹14.5 cr.
Excess payments to hospitals due to inflated gradings (Jul. '22 to Mar. '23)

₹10.8 cr.
Interest burden due to borrowings (2020-'22)

₹9.8 cr.
Refunds not received from insurance cos (2018-'22)

**from 2018 to 2023; all figures from CAG report*

sifications reduced reimbursements to government hospitals.

The more serious findings relate to private hospitals. Joint inspections conducted by audit teams and district officials across Hooghly, Purba Medinipur, Jalpaiguri, North 24 Parganas and Murshidabad found that 62 per cent of the 50 hospitals inspected deserved lower grades than those assigned to them. Faults cited include lack of prescribed infrastructure, bed strength, emergency facilities and manpower.

Five Grade A hospitals, 24 Grade B hospitals and two Grade C hospitals required downward revision. BJP leader and West Bengal health and family welfare minister Dr Sharadwat Mukherjee alleges that manipulating hospital gradings became an easy way to inflate reimbursements under the scheme. "A 10-bed nursing home was at par with Apollo Hospitals...there was a hike of 20-30 per cent with every escalation of grade," he claims.

Meanwhile, those who were closely involved with the scheme have distanced themselves from the findings. Former health minister Chandrima Bhattacharya, who has broken ranks with Mamata's TMC and is now part of the rebel party faction led by leader of the Opposition, Ritabrata Banerjee, declined to comment. "I have not seen the CAG report, so I can't comment on it. Also, I was never consulted for